Zewail City of Science and Technology

مدينة زويل للعلوم والتكنولوجيا

# Sociology

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# Culture & Society



# Introduction

- Sociologists study culture.
- Culture encompasses a group’s way of life, from routine everyday interactions to the most important parts of group members' lives.
- It includes everything produced by a society, including all the social rules.

## What is Culture?

- Culture refers to the way of life shared by a group of people—the knowledge, beliefs, values, rules or laws, language, customs, symbols, and material products (such as food, houses, and transportation) within a society that help meet human needs.
- Culture provides guidelines for living. Learning our culture puts our social world in an understandable framework, providing a tool kit we can use to help construct the meaning of our world.

## What is Society?

- A society is an organized and interdependent group of individuals who live together in a specific geographic area, who interact more with each other than they do with outsiders, who cooperate for the attainment of common goals, and who share a common culture over time.

- Each society includes key parts called institutions—family, education, religion, politics, economics, and health care or medicine—that meet basic human needs.

## How Society relates to Culture?

- Culture, the software, is learned, transmitted, shared, and reshaped from generation to generation. All activities in the society, whether educating young members, preparing and eating dinner, selecting leaders for the group, finding a mate, or negotiating with other societies, are guided by cultural rules and expectations.
- In each society, culture provides the social rules for how individuals carry out necessary tasks.

- Society — organized groups of people — and culture — their way of life — are interdependent. The two are not the same thing, but they cannot exist without each other, just as computer hardware and software are each useless without the other.
- The structures that make up society include the micro-level positions we hold (parent, student, and employee); the groups to which we belong (family, work group, and clubs); and the larger groups, organizations, or institutions in which we participate (education, political, and economic organizations).

## Characteristics of Culture

- All cultures have certain characteristics in common that define culture and illustrate the purposes it serves for our societies.

**1- All people share a culture with others in their society.**

- Culture provides the rules, routines, patterns, and expectations for carrying out daily rituals and interactions. Within a society, the process of learning how to act is called socialization. From birth, we learn the patterns of behavior approved in our society.

## 2- Culture evolves over time and is adaptive.

- What is normal, proper, and good behavior in hunter-gatherer societies, where cooperation and communal loyalty are critical to the hunt, differs from appropriate behavior in the information age, where individualism and competition are encouraged and enhance one's position and well-being.

## 3- The creation of culture is ongoing and cumulative.

- Individuals and societies continually build on existing culture to adapt to new challenges and opportunities.
- Your culture shapes the behaviors, values, and institutions that seem natural to you.

**4- The transmission of culture is the feature that most separates humans from other animals.**

- Some societies of higher primates have shared cultures but do not systematically enculturate (teach a way of life to) the next generation.
- Primate cultures focus on behaviors relating to obtaining food, use of territory, protection, and social status.

- Human cultures have significantly more content and are mediated by **language**.
- Humans are the only mammals with cultures that enable them to **adapt** to and even **modify** their environments so that they can survive on the equator, in the Arctic, or even beyond the planet.

# Ethnocentrism

- The tendency to view one's own group and its cultural expectations as right, proper, and superior to others is called ethnocentrism — "ethno" for ethnic group and "centrism" for centered on.
- As you can see, social values, beliefs, and behaviors can vary dramatically from one society to the next.
- These differences can be threatening and even offensive to people who judge others according to their own perspectives, experiences, and values.

- As scientists, sociologists must rely on scientific research to understand behavior.
- The scientific method calls for objectivity — the practice of considering observed behaviors independently of one's own beliefs and values.
- The study of social behavior, requires both sensitivity to a wide variety of human social patterns and a perspective that reduces bias.

- This is more difficult than it sounds because sociologists themselves are products of society and culture.
- All of us are raised in a particular culture that we view as normal or natural. Yet not every culture views the same things as “normal.”

## The Role of Ethnocentrism

- Societies instill some degree of ethnocentrism in their members because ethnocentric beliefs hold groups together and help members feel that they belong to the group.
- Ethnocentrism promotes loyalty, unity, high morale, and conformity to the rules of society.



- Fighting for one's country, for instance, requires some degree of belief in the rightness of one's own society and its causes.
- Ethnocentric attitudes also help protect societies from rapid, disintegrating change.
- If most people in a society did not believe in the rules and values of their own culture, the result could be widespread dissent, deviance, or crime.





- Unfortunately, ethnocentrism can lead to misunderstandings between people of different cultures.
- The same ethnocentric attitudes that strengthen ties between some people may encourage hostility, racism, war, and genocide against others — even others within the society — who are different.



- Virtually all societies tend to “demonize” their adversary — in movies, the news, and political speeches — especially when a conflict is most intense.



- Dehumanizing another group with labels makes it easier to torture or kill its members or to perform acts of discrimination and brutality against them.

# Cultural Relativism

- In contrast to ethnocentrism, cultural relativism requires setting aside cultural and personal beliefs and prejudices to understand another group or society through the eyes of its members and using its own community standards.
- Instead of judging cultural practices and social behavior as good or bad according to one's own cultural practices, the goal is to be impartial in learning the purposes and consequences of practices and behaviors of the group under study.



- Cultural relativism does not require that social scientists accept or agree with all the beliefs and behaviors of the societies or groups they study. Yet it allows them to try to understand those practices in the social and cultural contexts in which they occur.

- However, as we become a part of a global social world, it becomes increasingly important to understand and accept those who are “different.” Bigotry and attitudes of superiority do not enhance cross-national cooperation and trade — which is what the increasing movement toward a global village and globalization entails.

***Example: Attitudes toward time***

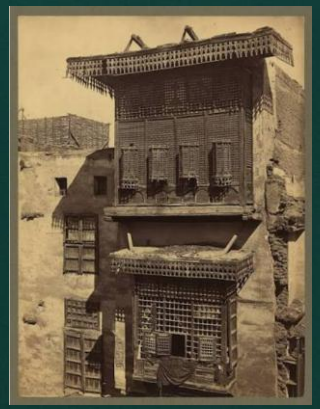
- Being tolerant and understanding is not always easy.
- Some behaviors or ideas in other cultures can be difficult for even the most objective observer to understand.
- The notion of being “on time,” for example, which is so much a part of the cultures of the United States, Canada, Japan, and parts of Europe, is a rather bizarre concept in some societies.

# Components of Culture:

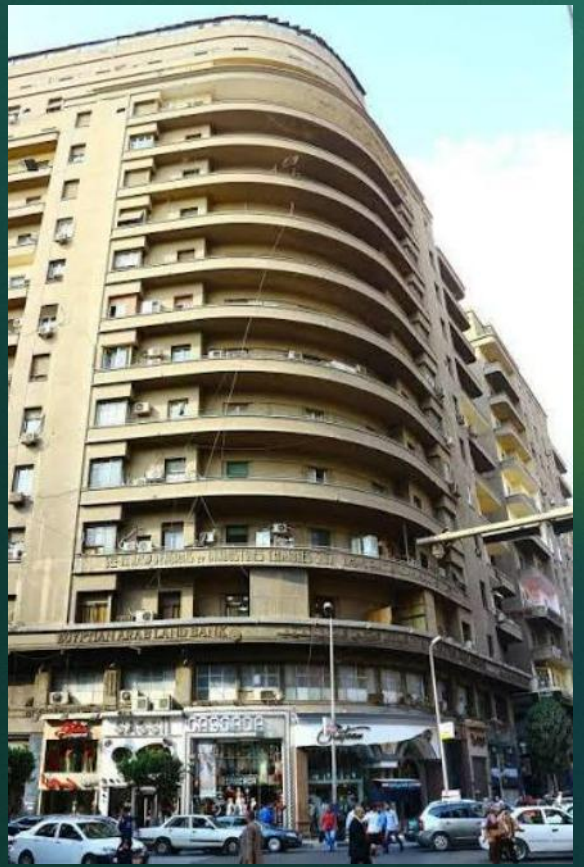
## A- Material Culture

- Material culture includes all the human-made objects we can see or touch, all the artifacts of a group of people
- Houses are an especially good example of material culture, because they result from local ideas of what a “home” looks like and shape the interactions and attitudes of people in the society.

- Likewise, types of jewelry, pottery, musical instruments, or clothing reflect tastes that emerge at the micro and meso levels of family, and community.







## B- Nonmaterial Culture

- They are the invisible and intangible parts of culture that involve society's rules of behavior, ideas, and beliefs
- Nonmaterial culture is complex, comprising four main elements: beliefs, values, norms, and language.

**1) Beliefs**

- are ideas we hold about life, about the way society works, and about where we fit into the world. They are expressed as specific statements that we hold to be true.

**2) Values**

- are the shared, abstract beliefs and ideals that a culture or society uses to assess what is good, right, desirable, and proper.

## 3) Norms

- are rules of behavior shared by members of a society and rooted in the value system. Examples include our rather routine behaviors, from saying “Hi” to people we meet to obeying traffic signs.

- Taboos are the strongest form of Norms. They concern actions considered *unthinkable* or *unspeakable* in the culture. For example, most societies have taboos that forbid incest (sexual relations with a close relative) and prohibit defacing or eating a human corpse.

## 4) Language

- Is the foundation of every culture. It conveys verbal, written, and nonverbal messages among members of society.
- Everyday millions of infants learn the language of the adults who care for them. In the process, they acquire an important part of culture, which is learned.
- Although many animals can communicate with a limited repertoire of sounds, the ability to speak a language is unique to humans.

- Through the use of language, members of a culture can pass on essential knowledge to children and can share ideas with other members of their society.

- Through language, members express their ideas, values, beliefs, and knowledge, a key ingredient in the ability of humans to sustain social life.



- Nonverbal language consists of gestures, facial expressions, and body postures. Communications scholars say this mode carries **93%** of the message: 55% in the facial expressions and 38% in the voice (vocal elements and intonation). That leaves 7% of the message coming from the actual words said!

(Debenham 2014; Fields 2015; Mehrabian 1972)

## The Linguistic Relativity Theory

- Language influences and shapes how we think, categorize information, and perceive the world, but does not strictly limit it.

Examples

- Grammatical Gender: Assigning a gender to an inanimate object (e.g., a bridge being feminine in German but masculine in Spanish) can subtly change how speakers describe that object.

- Spatial Orientation: Languages like Guugu Yimithirr use absolute cardinal directions (North, South, East, West) instead of relative terms (left, right). Speakers of these languages maintain an exceptional, constant sense of geographic orientation.

## When Biology meets Culture

- While culture frequently shapes how we live, biology sets the hard boundaries within which culture must develop.
- This means that human biological constraints, survival needs, and reproductive imperatives dictate the structures of our societies.

## 1- Altricial Birth & The Structure of the Family

- Unlike many mammals that can walk at birth, human infants are born highly altricial (helpless and neurologically undeveloped) due to a biological compromise between large human brains and narrow bipedal pelvises.
- The Cultural Result: Human babies require years of intensive care. This biological vulnerability directly dictated the cross-cultural invention of the extended family, kinship networks, and childcare systems.

## 2- Incest Avoidance

- Biologically, inbreeding increases the risk of harmful recessive genetic mutations.
- The Cultural Result: To prevent this, humans evolved a psychological mechanism called the Westermarck Effect: a natural sexual aversion to individuals they grew up with during early childhood. Culture formalizes this biological mechanism into strict legal, religious, and social incest taboos.

## Gene-Culture Coevolution

- Biology doesn't just dictate culture; culture can alter human biology over generations. This loop is known as gene-culture coevolution.
- This idea operates on the premise that human beings are shaped by two distinct, interacting streams of information: genetic information (passed down biologically through DNA) and cultural information (passed down socially through teaching, imitation, and language).

- When a society adopts a new cultural practice, it fundamentally alters the local environment.
- This new environment creates a fresh set of natural selection pressures, favoring individuals with specific genetic variations.
- Over generations, those genetic traits become dominant, locking the cultural practice into place because the population has become biologically adapted to it.

## Example: Agriculture and Disease Resistance

- One of the most clear-cut cases of culture changing genetics involves farming practices in West Africa.

[Cultural Choice] Cutting down forests to plant yams

[Environmental Change] Standing pools of water created

[Biological Shift] Malaria-carrying mosquitoes multiply rapidly

[Genetic Selection] Humans with the Sickle Cell trait survive malaria; the gene rapidly spreads through the population.

- The Culture: Traditional populations adopted intensive agricultural practices, specifically cutting down tropical rainforests to cultivate root crops like yams.
- The Environmental Shift: Clearing the dense tree canopy allowed sunlight to hit the forest floor, creating pools of stagnant rainwater. This environment served as the perfect breeding ground for Anopheles mosquitoes, which transmit malaria.

- The Genetic Adaptation: Individuals carrying a single copy of the mutated hemoglobin gene (the sickle cell trait) possessed a natural resistance to malaria.

- Because the cultural practice of farming increased malaria rates, it created a fierce evolutionary pressure that selected for this specific genetic mutation, making it highly prevalent in farming communities.

# Thanks!